

CORE MINISTER

COMMUNITY OUTREACH ENGAGEMENT MINISTER

2024 V.1

Dear CORE Minister,

Thank you for answering the call to serve as a CORE Minister. This is a very important commitment and role that will greatly impact the people who make up our community.

CORE Groups and CORE Ministers play a vital role in nurturing a thriving church community. They serve as catalysts for spiritual growth, fostering relationships, and providing the necessary encouragement for mutual edification, as emphasized in Proverbs 27:17, "Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another."

As the acronym suggests, CORE, which stands for Community Outreach Engagement, serves as a platform for sharing struggles, celebrating victories, and reinforcing spiritual foundations through the study of God's Word, prayer, and fellowship. We firmly believe that scripture underscores the significance of community as an integral aspect of the Kingdom.

In assuming the role of a CORE Minister, you are entering into a profound partnership not only with Garden City Church but with God's people at large. Ephesians 4:11-13 highlights this collaborative endeavor:

"And he gave the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, the shepherds and teachers, to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ."

Your labor is integral to the establishment and maturation of God's work within the hearts of His people. May you prosper and embrace this incredible ministry opportunity.

This handbook serves to elucidate your role and furnish you with the tools necessary to effectively serve as a CORE Minister.

Thank you again for your commitment to serving the Lord!

Pastor Aaron Rios

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UNIVERSAL SERVING STANDARDS, POLICIES and PROCEDURES

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Mission
Live the life. Tell the Story.

Vision
To know Christ and make Him known in our city and in every nation.

DISCIPLESHIP PROCESS

Serving God in the church is a profound privilege and our utmost reward. Our primary aim is to facilitate your spiritual growth as a valued member of our church family. As ministers of the gospel, our ongoing pursuit of Christ remains paramount alongside your personal devotion to Him. Garden City Church is dedicated to encountering Jesus and flourishing together. Our aspiration is for you to discern your gifts, deepen your faith, and impact the world around you. To this end, we strongly encourage you to walk through our discipleship process, outlined below:

1. Attend a NEXT NIGHT: Required

If you haven't attended a NEXT NIGHT before, we kindly ask that you join us for the upcoming session. The purpose is to familiarize you with our discipleship process and ensure a clear understanding of our church's mission and vision. This class is designed to set individuals on a healthy path, fostering unity and clarity within our church community. During NEXT NIGHT, you'll have the chance to tour our facility, learn about our ministries, hear the pastor's testimony, and discover ways to get involved. At the end of the session, you'll have the opportunity to ask any questions you may have.

2. Go through FOLLOWING JESUS: Required

The first step in our discipleship process is FOLLOWING JESUS. This step is designed for you to understand what it means to be a follower of Jesus at Garden City Church. Whether you're just beginning to explore who Jesus is or have been in church your whole life, it's important to approach your faith with a healthy understanding. If you haven't already, we encourage you to complete this class. It provides a comprehensive overview of fundamental Christian principles and illustrates how we apply these principles within our community.

3. Find a CORE MINISTER: Fulfilled

No one should walk alone, especially within the church community. It's all too common for Christians to feel isolated even in the midst of a congregation. Our aim at Garden City Church is to ensure that every individual engaged in Discipleship has a CORE Minister assigned to them. A CORE Minister serves as a supportive guide in the journey of discipleship, offering regular points of connection and encouragement. This might involve simple gestures like a monthly phone call, meeting for coffee, or coming together for prayer. CORE Ministers play a vital role in fostering a sense of belonging and support within our church community.

**For CORE Ministers, Pastor Aaron will serve as your direct CORE Minister*

4. Serve the Church: Encouraged/Fulfilled

We deeply appreciate your dedication to serving at Garden City Church. It's your willingness and commitment that enable our church to effectively minister to both our congregation and the wider community. Our aim is to empower you not only to serve within the church community but also to extend your ministry beyond our walls into the broader community. We believe that every individual is connected to at least one person whom they can lead to Jesus. Our goal is to assist you in discovering your unique place of ministry within Garden City Church and to equip you to share the message of Jesus beyond our church walls. We are confident that our discipleship processes will bring us closer to achieving this goal.

Key

Required: If 'required' is next to a step in the process, it means you must have completed this step (or you are currently completing it) before you can serve with this ministry.

Encouraged: If 'encouraged' is next to a step in the process, it means you are not required to complete this step, but we strongly encourage you to complete it for your own equipping and understanding.

Fulfilled: If 'fulfilled' is next to a step in the process, it means that by serving in this ministry, you are fulfilling this step.

5. Prayer: Required

"Prayer is the exercise of drawing on the grace of God." –Oswald Chambers

Prayer stands as a cornerstone of our ministry at Garden City Church, and we earnestly encourage all pastors, volunteers, and interns to actively engage in prayer in various capacities. We firmly believe that the growth of ministry is inseparable from one's personal prayer ethic and discipline. Our conviction in the power of prayer is unwavering; it is not a last resort but our first resolve. Prayer is our initial action and continual commitment. Paired with Scripture, prayer emerges as one of the most potent tools at a Christian's disposal. It is a means to healing and deliverance, and connects us directly to the presence of God. We facilitate opportunities such as Morning Intercession at 5 am and Tuesday Prayer services at 6:30 pm, continuously striving to equip and engage you in the transformative power of prayer. Matthew, one of the earliest followers of Jesus, recorded His words: "When you pray, don't babble like the Gentiles, for they think they will be heard because of their many words. Do not be like them, for your Father knows what you need before you ask Him" (Matthew 6:7-8). Jesus implies an expectation of prayer for His followers—it's a fundamental aspect of our identity.

Leaders and Prayer

We strive to cultivate an environment where individuals engage willingly rather than out of obligation alone. However, accountability, clear expectations, and deadlines can often elevate performance. At Garden City Church, we aim for team members to grasp the significance of prayer and to appreciate the impact of their contributions. As a CORE minister, it is expected that you are committed to participating in community prayer and to cultivating a thriving prayer life independently. To facilitate this, we offer numerous opportunities for leaders to actively participate as often as possible to make a meaningful contribution.

Corporate Prayer Opportunities

We engage in corporate prayer for several reasons. First, we see in Acts 2 a powerful model of communal interaction and engagement. Corporate prayer complements rather than replaces individual quiet time, enriching existing habits. Second, corporate prayer instills a sense of sacrifice and discipline in believers' lives. Leaders and interns are encouraged to participate in prayer through various avenues.

Tuesday Night Prayer

Every Tuesday night, from 6:30 pm to 8:00 pm, we gather in person for prayer. This session typically begins with quiet reflection/individual prayer, followed by a devotion, and then an opportunity for individuals to share in prayer. We see this as the Lord establishing a enduring pattern for prayer, and every believer is warmly welcomed to join us in this sacred time.

Morning ZOOM Prayer

Every morning, starting at 5 am, we come together virtually (with cameras usually off) for a dedicated prayer session. This period usually includes a brief devotional followed by a rotation of individuals engaging in prayer. The focus of this time is to deeply intercede, urging all participants to actively participate in prayer. Mondays are dedicated to men, Tuesday through Thursday are for the entire community, and Fridays are dedicated for women.

In Luke's second account of Jesus and His followers, he notes that Jesus' followers had a number of consistent practices every time they gathered. He writes this: "They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching [Scripture], to the fellowship, to the breaking of bread, and to prayer." (Acts 2:42). It's clear from scripture that prayer is a big part of the corporate gathering of Jesus followers. In every service where we gather together, we should pray. This is because our gatherings are dependent on God and not the people leading it. There are intentional times of prayer in corporate gatherings, especially leading into our time of singing and praise. Prayer will look different in different gatherings. Nonetheless, it's important prayer is done with the gathering of Jesus followers. It's a signal that the service is looking toward God and not people for direction and hope.

In our services you may also notice a Prayer Team at the end of the pastor's message. This is an opportunity for people to join in prayer with another Jesus follower. There are many reasons why someone may come forward to pray. You can pray with someone because of your gratitude to God, a sin in your life, for someone who is in need, or perhaps your own needs. We are strategic about having people pray with others, because prayer is supposed to be done in community.

DID YOU KNOW?

Prayer engages the fullness of God. When we pray, we pray in Jesus' name to God the Father through the Holy Spirit. Imagine God the Father as a cell tower, Jesus as the phone, and the Holy Spirit as the signal being transmitted. A phone call needs all components to work properly. Similarly, in prayer, we utilize the fullness of God in a miraculous way.

CORE VALUES

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Core values are fundamental beliefs that guide the attitudes, behaviors, and decisions of an organization or a community. They represent the deeply held principles and ideals that shape the culture and identity of a group. Core values serve as a compass, helping to align actions and priorities with the overarching mission and vision of the organization.

1. Biblically Grounded:

- The Bible is our ultimate authority, serving as our manual and foundation.
- We believe in the dependability and truthfulness of the Word of God, evidenced by personal testimony and historical data.
- Over the course of 1,500+ years, the Bible has been canonized and preserved, with more evidence for its authenticity than any other literature in antiquity.
- The Bible reveals God's truth to humanity and teaches us the path to salvation.

2. Pentecostal/Holy Spirit Empowered:

- We embrace the power of the Holy Spirit, as demonstrated in Acts 2, where the early church experienced supernatural manifestations such as healing, deliverance, and bold proclamation of the Word.
- Our community is committed to welcoming the gifts of the Spirit and passionately pursuing God's agenda.
- We strive to maintain an environment aligned with the activities and approval of the Holy Spirit.

3. Community Driven:

- Inspired by Matthew 25:31-46, we prioritize serving and caring for one another, recognizing that our actions towards fellow believers reflect our commitment to Christ.
- By equipping our community we can extend our support and ministry, enabling believers to participate fully in the mission of the church - reaching the ends of the world!

4. Relationally Nurturing:

- Rooted in 1 John 4:7-8, we emphasize the importance of love within our community, understanding that our health as a church is directly linked to our ability to love one another.

5. Mission and Evangelism Oriented:

- Our mission, as outlined in Matthew 28:19-20, is to make disciples of all nations, baptizing them and teaching them to obey Christ's commands.
- We recognize evangelism as a fundamental responsibility of every believer and endeavor to share the message of Christ with others.

6. Generous:

- Ephesians 2:4-10 reminds us of God's generosity towards us, motivating us to be generous in return.
- Generosity is both an act of obedience to God and a means through which the mission of the church is accomplished.

Proverbs 11:25, Matthew 10:8, Luke 6:38

7. Pursuing Excellence:

- Pursuing excellence means holding ourselves to the highest standards set by God and striving for excellence in all aspects of our lives.
- We seek excellence in our faith, speech, knowledge, earnestness, love, work, and proclamation of God's excellencies.

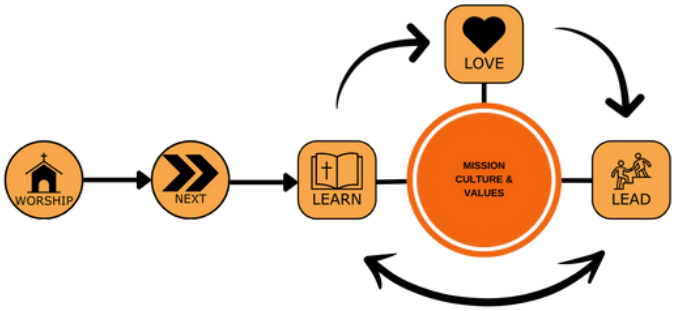
IMPORTANT
Our values help us bring commonality and clarity in many aspects of our church and keep us focused on our mission. By honoring these values, we are able to discern how we aim to conduct ourselves individually and in our ministry activities.

ABOUT BEING A LEADER

STANDARDS AND APPROPRIATE CONDUCT

CORE Ministers are both leaders and ministers. This is not a light responsibility. Though some people might not feel prepared enough, qualified or capable, we believe all Christians should possess the basic qualities and skills to effectively minister, at minimal, to one person.

Step into Community



BEING A GROUP LEADER

Anyone who leads in the church, in any capacity, must take seriously the words of Jesus. As He gathered His most trusted followers around Him, He made clear: *"You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and those in high positions act as tyrants over them. It must not be like that among you. On the contrary, whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant, and whoever wants to be first among you must be your slave; just as the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many"* (Matthew 20:25-28). ***You are to be a servant leader.***

- A servant leader has high integrity. If you don't know the answer, say that. But then research the answer and follow up later.
- A servant leader listens to others. When people speak, no matter what they are saying, you intently and carefully listen.
- Servant leaders are consistent. Show up for others each and every week. Stay in contact with those you serve.
- Servant leaders work hard for others. Be prepared for those you lead.

Your commitment will influence the way others grow and follow Jesus. You are essential to this process!

BEING A PARTICIPANT

The first century Jesus follower, John—the beloved disciple—challenges us in his first letter by clarifying the goal of every Christ follower. He says it like this:

> *"This is how we know that we know him: if we keep His commands. The one who says, "I have come to know Him," and yet doesn't keep His commands, is a liar, and the truth is not in Him. But whoever keeps His word, truly in him the love of God is made complete. This is how we know we are in Him: The one who says he remains in Him should walk just as He walked."*
> –1 John 2:3-6

We are supposed to live exactly like Jesus did. That's a high calling. Yet, becoming like Jesus doesn't happen overnight. We believe it happens in steps. One step at a time we become more like Jesus. However, each step must be deliberate and intentional. The fact that you are in this group is a step. But you must take one step after another. Commit to the next step. First, commit to showing up every week. Second, commit to learning as much as you can by participating and asking questions. Third, commit to practicing what you learn. Finally, commit to taking the next step each week as next steps are presented. You will be given opportunities to serve and connect: take the step!

WHAT IS A CORE MINISTER?

Defining the roles and responsibilities of CORE Ministers is crucial. Every individual involved in ministry, from pastors to volunteers, must have a clear identity and be able to prioritize safeguarding marriage, motherhood/fatherhood, mental/emotional well-being, spiritual health, and time management. Considering that volunteers often juggle demanding schedules outside of church commitments, it's essential not to overburden them. Setting healthy boundaries ensures sustainable and effective ministry practices.

WHAT?

A CORE Minister is a lay minister appointed to serve as a primary liaison for a designated group of church members. Their responsibilities include identifying individual needs, nurturing spiritual development, and supporting Christian growth. Each CORE Minister will be assigned a caseload of up to 5 dedicated church members who are actively engaged in the discipleship journey at Garden City Church.

WHY?

A thriving church community actively involves its members in ministry, as instructed by scripture. By doing so, we foster a culture where reliance isn't solely on the pastoral team, but where mutual care and ministry flourish among members. While this doesn't diminish the importance of pastoral leadership, it amplifies the community's effectiveness by nurturing the diverse gifts and talents within it.

PURPOSE:

1. Obey Ephesians 4:12-16
2. Steward every individual entering GCC.
3. Facilitate spiritual growth, foster discipleship, and provide accountability.
4. Understand the unique needs of individuals
5. Guide individuals toward maturity in their spiritual journey.
6. Knowing each person on a deeper level.
7. Holistic development within the church community.

SPIRITUAL BASICS:

To effectively encourage others in Christian behavior and character growth, we must first be actively pursuing these traits ourselves. As the Apostle Paul noted, "Not that I have already obtained all this, or have already arrived at my goal, but I press on to take hold of that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me" (Philippians 3:12). The aim is not to wait until every Christian achieves perfection before they can serve or lead, but rather to ensure that we are continually striving towards higher values and embracing our calling in Christ.

QUALIFICATIONS OF A CORE MINISTER

- Actively care for others (Acts 20:28-31, Ephesians 6:10-18, 1 Peter 5:2-3).
- Initiate reconciliation, practicing forgiveness.
- Engage in the spiritual growth of others through evangelism and discipleship.
- Serve as a living example of Christ for others (1 Corinthians 10:31 - 11:1).
- Pursue a higher road, prioritizing the well-being of others over personal rights.
- Serve people willingly (Matthew 20:25-28, John 13:1-17, Philippians 2:3-4).
- Exhibit qualities listed in 1 Timothy 3:1-13/Titus 1:5-9.
- Take responsibility for the health and condition of the church.

SPECIFIC DUTIES AND TIME COMMITMENT

1. **Regular Connection:** ***5-10 Minutes - twice a month***
   - Bi-weekly phone or text contact with up to 5 assigned community members.
2. **Personal Interaction:** ***30 Minutes - once a month***
   - Monthly in-person meetings outside of church. *Book Study or Bible study is encouraged
   - Engage in intentional prayer, facilitate spiritual growth, and provide monthly reports to the Pastor on individuals' spiritual conditions, pressing needs, and challenges.

**TOTAL MONTHLY TIME COMMITMENT = 3HRS 20MINUTES PER MONTH*

!IMPORTANT!
Individuals assigned CORE Ministers must actively participate in our discipleship process to safeguard our CORE Ministers. This ensures that before assigning responsibility for an individual, we have a deeper understanding of our community members. This precaution helps prevent situations that may be unsafe or require more than what a CORE Minister is designated to handle. Furthermore, we strictly adhere to assigning men to men and women to women for accountability and appropriateness.

WHAT A CORE LEADER IS NOT

BOUNDARIES

When interacting with individuals, it's common to encounter situations where we may be tempted to step beyond our qualifications or abilities. However, staying firmly within our boundaries and area of expertise is essential to prevent overcommitment and avoid being asked to undertake tasks or services for which we are not qualified or equipped. Below are specific boundaries to operate in.

YOU ARE NOT A:

SOCIAL WORKER:
You are not to serve solely as a means to locate community resources for individuals.

COUNSELOR:
You are not to provide professional counsel beyond the scope of advice.

MEDICAL PROFESSIONAL:
You are prohibited from making diagnoses or medical recommendations, including dietary advice.

PASTOR:
While providing spiritual development, you are not to replace the pastor or offer pastoral advice on behalf of Garden City Church.

SAFETY EXPERT:
You are not to provide safety advice in health, wellness, or business matters.

MENTAL HEALTH COACH:
You are not to offer advice on individuals' mental health conditions. If deeper spiritual consideration is warranted, consult the lead pastor.

LIFE COACH:
You are prohibited from prescribing life-coaching.

THEOLOGIAN:
As a CORE Minister, you are not an apologist or theologian. If you don't know the answer to theological questions, it's acceptable to humbly say "I don't know" and avoid fruitless theological discussions.

AVOID SOLICITATION OR ENGAGING IN COMMERCE:
CORE Ministers should refrain from using their position for personal business or financial gain.

PROHIBITION ON PROVIDING INCOME OR RESOURCES:
CORE Ministers are not to assume financial burdens for individuals without consulting the pastor. If assistance is necessary, funds should be requested through the church for proper tracking and stewardship. Personal donations should also be channeled through the church for accountability and responsible allocation of resources.

BOTTOM LINE, CORE Ministers Do the Following:

1. Spiritual Guidance and Support:
A CORE Minister can regularly check in with their assigned group of church members, providing spiritual encouragement, praying with them, and offering guidance on matters of faith and personal growth.

2. Facilitating Small Group Discussions:
Organizing and leading small group meetings or discussions focused on relevant spiritual topics, Bible study, or personal development can help foster community and deepen members' understanding of their faith.

3. Connecting Members with the Church:
CORE Ministers can help encourage individuals to grow deeper in the discipleship processes of Garden City Church with the ultimate goal of your caseload becoming a CORE Minister.

RESOURCES

TO HELP PREPARE YOU TO MINISTER, CONSIDER THE FOLLOWING:

BOOKS

1. "Power Evangelism" by John Wimber
2. "Fresh Wind, Fresh Fire" by Jim Cymbala
3. "The Spirit-Filled Church: Finding Your Place in God's Purpose" by Jack Hayford
4. "Servant Leadership: A Journey into the Nature of Legitimate Power and Greatness" by Robert K. Greenleaf
5. "Empowered Evangelicals: Bringing Together the Best of the Evangelical and Charismatic Worlds" by Rich Nathan and Ken Wilson
6. "Receiving the Holy Spirit Today" by Victor Paul Wierwille
7. "The Practice of the Presence of God" by Brother Lawrence
8. "Pentecostalism: The World Their Parish" by David Martin
9. "Fire in My Bones: Transcendence and the Holy Spirit in African American Gospel" by Glenn Hinson
10. "Spirit and Truth: Reclaiming the Heart of Worship" by Aaron Rios

OTHER RESOURCES

1. The Bible App
2. Bible Engagement Project